

Introduction

For nearly 20 years, ThinkWorkStories! has been studying and developing stories about the practices and strategies that support people with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD) to live and work successfully in their communities. Many stories this year focused on the use of self-directed services to achieve competitive integrated employment and community life engagement.

Self-direction is a Medicaid service model that allows people with IDD to directly manage their own services and supports. Research shows that the use of self-directed services significantly enhances quality of life and offers an alternative path to achieving competitive integrated employment and community life engagement outcomes (Kulchinsky et al., 2021; Caldwell & Heller, 2007; Bogenschutz et al., 2019). Internationally, self-direction is viewed as a valuable service model due to its person-centered nature, individualized approach, and promotion of community integration (Bradley et al., 2021). In the US, nearly one-third of Medicaid Home and Community Based Services (HCBS) have the option for self-direction, which can include a range of employer authority (e.g., hiring and managing staff) and budget authority (e.g., managing HCBS funds; Friedman, 2024).

Although about 80% of states allow self-direction within their HCBS waivers for people with IDD, only about 13% of people with IDD nationwide self-directed their HCBS in FY 2021 (Friedman, 2024). This is despite Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS) (2014, 2019) urging states to expand self-direction and make HCBS more person-centered in alignment with the HCBS Settings Rule (CMS, n.d.). This results in missed opportunities to promote choice, individual control, respect, and self-determination, while ensuring full access to work, community involvement, and a fulfilling life.

Individuals and families who have budget authority and employer authority over their services have the significant responsibility of managing the financial and logistical aspects of receiving these services. However, the limited research on self-directed services reports that the benefits of self-directed services, such as individuals' and families' sense of control over meeting personal and medical needs and pursuing community integration and employment goals, are perceived by service recipients to be worthwhile trade-offs. In addition, state program administrators report that the effective management of self-directed services can be cost saving for providers (Bogenschutz et al., 2019).

The Institute for Community Inclusion at UMass Boston conducted a qualitative study to learn about the experiences of individuals with IDD who self-direct their



employment services. The study aimed to identify strategies and practices that have been effective in achieving employment outcomes. The study conducted semi-structured interviews with people with IDD, their family members, and supports brokers from different states across the country to better understand their experiences with self-directed services, resulting in seven individual ThinkWork! stories.

This brief is #3 in a series highlighting the strategies people with IDD and their family members use to self-direct their services. Brief #3 highlights strategies for people with IDD and their families to manage the finances and logistics that make self-direction possible.

What Services to Manage

Across the study, participants focused on their individual goals related to employment and structured their services accordingly. Self-directed services, by their nature, allow people to focus on the things that are important to them to lead a fulfilling life. Participants in this study managed different types of services to support their independent living and employment goals. One participant worked with her supports broker to self-direct services for job coaching to increase her productivity and income through part-time employment and self-employment. Another participant and his family planned a structured, enjoyable day that included self-directing services during a set number of work hours to acquire and maintain a successful, meaningful job. While yet another participant found that transportation was possibly his biggest barrier to working and being in the community, and he appreciated the sense of control that self-directed services gave him to purchase and maintain an accessible car.

How to Manage Services

Individuals and families had the authority to decide how to hire staff, set pay rates, give raises, and determine schedules depending on the supports they needed. This is known as employer authority within self-directed services. Some individuals appreciated the stability and comfort level of hiring trusted friends and family. Others used the option to hire through an agency that vetted applicants and paid them, which reduced administrative burden. Several participants hired friends or relatives and they or their family members learned to manage payroll. Other individuals also hired family and friends and additional short-term supporters through an agency to simplify the process of finding daily support for transportation to and from work and personal needs at work.

Participants spoke about being involved with managing their self-directed services budgets to the best of their abilities, known within self-directed services as budget authority. One participant met regularly with her employment team to align current priorities with available funds. Another participant and his family learned about everything having a line item in his budget to plan for support for all his home, work, and community activities and assistive technology for work. While yet another participant used an app on her phone to fill in staff time sheets and preferred to rely on her parents and support broker to help with budgeting and tracking expenses.

When to Manage Services

Most of the participants using self-directed services for their employment services reported working with fiscal intermediaries and/or with a support circle to manage self-directed services in their homes and communities. It took time and the help of trusted family members and friends to learn to manage self-directed services for better employment options. For example, one participant emphasized learning responsibilities gradually, having an agency support him at first to keep records and pay for services, and later taking on payroll and budgeting with the help of a circle of trusted friends for support. Another participant learned about budgeting, acknowledged that budgeting was not her strength, and mostly delegated this activity to her family and her consultant. Families stressed the importance of patience, training, and asking for help when needed.

Strategies & Suggestions for People with IDD and Their Families:

- » **Take time to learn how self-directed services can help.** States have differences in whether self-directed services can be used directly for employment or for support with other areas of life, such as personal care and transportation. Individuals and families who can use self-directed service for employment might consider their employment possibilities with or without self-directed service. Individuals and families found the financial side of self-directed service easier to manage when they were aware of the benefits of self-directed service.
- » **“Self-directed” does not mean doing everything yourself.** Individuals and families may work with a fiscal intermediary and can get support as needed with any difficult skills or questions.
- » **Get involved in managing your services to the best of your interest and ability.** Even with support to manage self-directed services, individuals can learn more as they go. It makes sense to set a goal to learn as much as possible about what it means to budget and keep records, and learn what is happening and what else could be done with self-directed services funds.

Conclusion

Responsible management of self-directed services supports the overall success of the model. Participants shared about their choice to self-direct employment services and their experiences finding funds for employment services, working with trusted support, and learning to budget and submit records to fiscal intermediaries. But the challenging financial management responsibilities were simply seen as part of self-directing their services. They recognized that ultimately, the work put into managing services is worthwhile since self-directed services enable more choice, independence, and improved quality of life.

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